

Spaceship

By Ruby Gsanger

When I look back on my childhood, I'm often able to piece together certain moments and make sense of small details that felt insurmountable at the time. During my introspection, I tie these quiet moments into lessons, shattering my cocky expectation that I am the way I am because of choice, and reinforcing that my experiences shape who I am.

I like to imagine that these memories are packaged unassumingly in quaint, light blue, velvet boxes, which usually are finished with a neat bow. Every once in a while, I'll pull one of these memories (located on the top shelf of the favorite memories armoire in my brain) off of its neatly organized and dusted shelf.

I pull on the loose ends of the bow, and allow the satin ribbon to drop to the floor. The box habitually pops open, and my face is hit with the glow of a warm memory:

It's hot outside. Hotter than usual. Summer is coming. When I look down, my shoes are buried in the mulch of the playground, which emits that nostalgic smell of the little montessori school I attend. I take a step, and then another, and I slowly start into a clumsy run, looking ahead at the slide. But suddenly, I hear my stomach roar, and I realize that I didn't eat lunch.

One of the defining qualities of my childhood, which I regrettably carry into my teenage years, is my pickiness.

I turned up my nose at the food my mom carefully packed in my lunchbox, unaware of the effort and love she put into each item. An average lunch would contain: homemade applesauce, a peanut butter and jelly sandwich, and some sort of fruit (usually handpeeled oranges).

Looking back, this was standard as a pre-Kindergartener, but each morning on the ride to school in our 'spaceship' car, I would dread lunch time. Not because I had a certain disdain for my mother's effort, but because I didn't like being told what to do, and that, to my mother's disapproval, translated into refusing to eat when my teachers told me to.

In an effort to distract my mother, and capitalize on that distraction by leaving my lunch box in the car, I would pester her by begging for directions that I could plug into my 'console' on the ship.

"Where's Mars, mama?"

"I think it's right next to the Sprouts, honey."

"Where's Sprouts, mama?"

That kind of thing. But, my older sister (who wasn't trying to be helpful) would slyly remind my mother to make sure I had my lunchbox when the carpool attendant (who was really an eighth grade volunteer) would pluck me out of my car seat and usher me inside to my grinning teachers. And of course, I would downright refuse to get out of the car unless it was my favorite eighth grader, and would throw a fit in any other scenario.

As the warm glow of the memory shines on my face, I watch as my stubbornness prevails, and I refuse to eat my lunch. This proved hazardous since after lunch time, we had recess.

While everyone runs around and plays 'stuck in the mud', all I can think about is how much I want Goldfish.

I consider asking my teacher to let me back inside so I could eat some of my lunch (for real this time, I promise), but I reluctantly decide that they would tell my mom, and I'm not ready for that conversation.

I wasn't ready for a lot of things.

Instead I decide to scale the rope ladder, and hoist myself onto the play structure. The sun is beating uncomfortably on my back, so I seek shade under the awning of the plastic tower. I slump down against the metal railing and take a deep breath.

After a while (probably a minute or two. Another defining trait of my childhood was impatience), I hear a spaceship pull into the parking lot, and I hop onto my feet.

Because I'm on the tall play structure, I'm able to see over the wooden fence that separated our guarded playground from the outside world. I see my spaceship. I see my mom.

At this point (if my small velvet box hadn't been tampered with and the memory was still fully intact allowing me to recall the details correctly), I only went to school for half of the day. My mom would usually pick me up from school after lunch, and I would hug all of my Kindergarten friends goodbye, who were older than me and had to stay for the rest of the day.

I use the fire pole to slide down to the mulch, and I trip over myself trying to run over to my teacher.

"Ms. Nupor, my mama's here."

"Ok, Ruby. You have to wait until she comes to get you from the gate."

"No, I promise I'm big enough to walk over to her myself! I'll look both ways in the parking lot!"

"No, Ruby. You have to wait."

If you recall, I was not a patient child.

I run over to the gate, and jump, trying to catch a glimpse of my mom nearing the playground.

Luckily, she is right on the other side, and promptly unlatches the gate. I give her a huge hug (like really big) and she swiftly scoops me off my feet, and situates me on her hip.

I could swear she had a glow about her. A halo-looking, gold ring around her head. Or the velvet box could be taking its own creative liberties.

"Where's your lunch bag, lovie?"

I stop for a second, maybe out of shame, to think.

"It's in my cubby, mama."

"Go and grab it."

She swings open the door to my classroom, which is closely located to the gate of the playground. I run in, past the rest of my classmates who are filing in and getting ready for reading time, and fall to my knees at my cubby. I fish around, and pull out my tattered lunchbox.

I brush off my dirty leggings, because this is the ground of a Kindergarten classroom, after all. I jump to my feet, and meet my mom at the door.

I remember my growling stomach, and when the hot air hits my face again, I say something peculiar:

“Mama, I have a headache. And this time, it actually hurts.”

A shadow crosses over my face, and I look up to a dark sky.

My mom laughs, and asks me, “Well, what else would a headache do?”

She promises, “You’ll get used to it soon enough.”

But I’m stunned. Normally, my mama’s promises are like gold, just like the halo that floats above her head. This promise doesn’t seem so radiant.

I walk back to our spaceship, only it is no longer a spaceship. It is just a car. The back of my mom’s seat is no longer equipped with a console; it is only adorned with the dirt marks from my small feet, and the grimy fingerprints I had left that morning. We no longer take off the ground, and hover in the parking lot. We only drive out, and take a right.

I sit in the car, distinctly disappointed.

I never thought it would be possible to pinpoint a moment when a childhood loses its glow, its promise of imagination— but this had to be it. My first headache, and the dull ride back home, in a car that certainly wasn’t a spaceship.

The memory dims, and the box slowly closes on itself. The show is over. I reach down and carefully tie the ribbon back into a neat bow, and place the small velvet box back onto its shelf. I retreat away from the armoire, and shake myself out of my daze.

I look around my messy room, and the pile of homework sitting on my desk, reminding myself to check my emails and cross everything off my to-do list. I take an Advil.